



Shmeera

Children's Check-In & Safety — User Manual

A practical guide for Guardians, Staff, and Admins

Shmeera makes sure only a verified, authorized adult can ever pick up a checked-in child — and gives every family a direct line to their child's room during a service.

Version 1.0 · Generated for the current build of the Shmeera platform.

Every screen, button, and flow described here reflects the live application — not a plan for one.

Contents

1.	Welcome to Shmeera
2.	Creating Your Account
3.	Guardian Guide
4.	Staff Guide
5.	Admin Guide
6.	How Shmeera Keeps Children Safe
7.	Troubleshooting & FAQ

Welcome to Shmeera

Shmeera is a check-in and check-out system for a church or ministry's children's program. It exists to answer one question with total confidence, every single time: **"Is the person picking up this child actually allowed to?"**

Every ministry that uses Shmeera is its own independent, fully isolated **organization**. Nothing you do is ever visible to another church using the same app — separate rooms, separate children, separate staff, separate history.

The three roles

Role	What they do
GUARDIAN	A parent or caregiver. Registers their children, checks them in and out of a room, adds other adults who are allowed to pick a child up, and can message the room directly while their child is checked in.
STAFF	Runs a room. Accepts drop-offs against a code the parent shows them, verifies a pickup code before releasing a child, messages guardians, and can flag or report a problem.
ADMIN	Approves staff accounts, manages rooms, watches every room at once, reviews the full history of what happened and when, runs attendance/pickup reports, and holds the few controls (manual override, data purge) that need a level of trust above staff.

THE ONE RULE EVERYTHING ELSE FOLLOWS

Generating a check-in or pickup code never changes anything by itself. A code only ever does something once a second, independent person — the staff member actually standing in the room — enters it and confirms. One side alone can't check a child in or let them leave.

What you'll need

- A phone, tablet, or computer with a web browser and an internet connection.
- An email address to sign up with.
- For guardians and staff joining an existing ministry: an **invite code** from your ministry's admin (guardians) or a login your admin creates directly for you (staff).

Creating Your Account

WHERE TO GO

Open <https://shmeera.vercel.app/> in your browser to sign up or sign in. Consider bookmarking it, or adding it to your phone's home screen, for quick access on drop-off/pickup days.

Starting a brand-new ministry

If your church or ministry has never used Shmeera before, one person — usually the children's ministry director — signs up and starts it. That person automatically becomes the ministry's first **ADMIN**.

- 1 Open the app and choose **Sign up**, then the **"Start a new ministry"** tab.
- 2 Enter your ministry or church name — this is just a label, e.g. "One Church International."
- 3 Fill in your name, email, and a password (at least 8 characters).
- 4 Check the consent box and select **Create account**.
- 5 If your ministry requires email confirmation, you'll see a "Check your email" screen — click the link in that email, then come back and sign in.

Joining an existing ministry (guardians)

If your ministry already uses Shmeera, ask your admin for the ministry's **invite code** (they can find it under Staff accounts in their Admin view).

- 1 Choose **Sign up**, then the **"I have an invite code"** tab.
- 2 Enter the invite code exactly as given to you.
- 3 Fill in your name, email, phone (optional), and password.
- 4 Check the consent box and select **Create account**.

NOTE

There's no public directory of churches to browse — an invite code is the only way to join an existing ministry as a guardian. This keeps each ministry's family list private to that ministry.

Staff and additional admins

Staff accounts are never self-signup. Your admin creates your login directly (see Chapter 5) and gives you the email and temporary password to sign in with — change your password after your first login. The same is true for a second admin account: only an existing admin can create another one.

Signing in, forgotten passwords

Use **Sign in** with your email and password. If you forget your password, select **Forgot password?** on the sign-in screen to receive a reset link by email.

STAYING SIGNED IN

Shmeera does not automatically sign you out after a period of inactivity — once signed in, you stay signed in until you choose to sign out. If your ministry uses a shared or public tablet rather than each staff member's own phone, make a habit of signing out manually between shifts.

Guardian Guide

Your dashboard

After signing in, you land on **My children** — a card for each child you've registered, showing their current status and the next action available (Check in, Pick up now, or View status). If you haven't added a child yet, you'll be prompted to.

Adding a child

- 1 From your dashboard, select **Manage children & pickup list**, then **+ Add a child**.
- 2 Enter their full name and date of birth.
- 3 Optionally pick a default room/class — leave it on "Auto-suggest room by age" and Shmeera will suggest the right room based on the child's age at check-in time.
- 4 Add any medical or allergy notes — these are only ever visible to staff actually assigned to the room your child is checked into, never to other guardians.
- 5 Select **Save child**, then upload a photo. A photo is how staff visually confirm the right child is being dropped off or picked up — add one as soon as you can.

Authorized pickup people

By default, only *you* can pick up your child. If a grandparent, babysitter, or anyone else might need to pick your child up, add them to that child's pickup list first — under **Manage** on the child's card, then **+ Add authorized pickup person**.

- Give their name, relationship to the child, and (optionally) an ID reference and photo.
- Each pickup person has a status: **Active** (can be selected at pickup), **Inactive** (temporarily off the list), or **Blocked** — explicitly not authorized, with a reason staff will see if anyone tries to use their name.

WHY THIS MATTERS

A person can only ever be presented as a checkout requester if you specifically added them. There's no way for anyone — including staff or an admin — to add themselves to your child's pickup list.

Checking in a child

- 1 From your dashboard, select **Check in** on the child's card.
- 2 Confirm or change the room, then select **Generate check-in code**.

- 3 You'll see a QR code and a short text code, plus the option to print a paper backup tag (useful if your phone battery is a concern, or the venue has poor signal).
- 4 Show the code to the staff member in the room. Nothing happens until *they* enter it on their end and confirm your child matches the photo on file.

Once accepted, the card updates to **Checked in** automatically — no need to refresh.

Picking up a child

There are two ways to start a pickup:

- **Pick up now** (on the dashboard) — the fast path when you're picking up yourself. It generates a code immediately.
- **View status** → **Pick up** — use this if someone *else* on the child's pickup list is doing the pickup instead of you. You'll choose who from a drop-down before the code is generated.

Either way, show the resulting code (or the printed backup tag) to a staff member in the room — your child is only released once staff independently confirm it.

IF SOMEONE IS TURNED AWAY

If you try to select a pickup person marked Blocked, Shmeera will tell you they are "explicitly not authorized" rather than silently failing — this is intentional, so there's never ambiguity about why.

Messaging staff

While your child is checked in, a **Message guardian** / chat panel is available from the session's status page, so you can ask the room a question during the service. Mark a message **urgent** if it needs immediate attention — an unread urgent message automatically escalates to your ministry's admin after a short delay.

Checking in or picking up multiple children at once

If you have more than one child eligible at the same time, your dashboard shows **Check in multiple children** and/or **Pick up multiple children** shortcuts — select several at once instead of repeating the single-child flow.

Notifications

The bell icon in the header shows updates for your family — a check-in accepted, a pickup confirmed, a check-in declined, and so on — even after you've closed and reopened the app.

History and your data

- **History** shows every past session for your children.

- **Export my data** (on your dashboard) downloads a JSON file with your profile, children, their pickup people, and their session history.
- **Remove child** (under Manage) hides a child from your account. Past check-in records for that child are kept — this protects the ministry's safety accountability record — but the child no longer appears in your day-to-day list.

Staff Guide

Getting approved

Your admin creates your login directly, then either approves it immediately or leaves it pending. Until an admin marks you **Approved** and assigns you to at least one room, you'll see a waiting screen instead of the room dashboard.

Your room dashboard

Once approved and assigned, your **Room dashboard** shows three lists for your room, updating live:

- **Pending check-ins** — children a guardian has generated a code for but who haven't been accepted into the room yet.
- **Pending pickups** — children whose guardian (or an authorized pickup person) has generated a pickup code.
- **Checked in** — children currently in your room.

If you're assigned to more than one room, a room selector appears at the top.

Accepting a check-in

- 1 Ask the parent for the check-in code on their screen (or scan/read their printed backup tag).
- 2 Confirm the child in front of you matches the photo shown on the card.
- 3 Enter the code and select **Confirm**.

WRONG CODE

If the code doesn't match, Shmeera tells you plainly rather than silently failing or accepting anyway — try again, or ask the parent to confirm the code on their screen.

A child **transferred in** from another room shows "Accept transfer" instead of a code field — confirm the child matches the photo, no code is needed for a transfer someone already sent to you.

You can also **Decline / hold** a check-in (with an optional reason) if something isn't right — for example, a missing photo you can't verify against.

Confirming a pickup

A pending pickup card shows exactly who is requesting the child — their name, photo, and relationship. Ask that adult for the pickup code, confirm it matches, and enter it to release the child.

MISMATCH OR FAILED ATTEMPT

If a code doesn't match or something feels wrong, use **Flag mismatch / failed attempt** to describe what happened. This creates an incident your admin will see immediately — always use this instead of just trying again silently.

Transferring a child to another room

Use **Transfer to another room** on a pending or checked-in child's card if they need to move mid-service (e.g. moved to the right age group). The destination room's staff still has to separately accept the transfer — you can't unilaterally move a child into a room without that room's staff confirming.

Messaging guardians

Select **Message guardian** on a checked-in child's card to open a chat thread with that family for the duration of the session.

Reporting an incident

Use the **Report an incident** button (always visible on your dashboard) for anything that isn't specifically a pickup mismatch — an injury, a behavior issue, anything your admin should know about, tied to your room.

Acting straight from a notification

When a parent generates a check-in or pickup code, you get a notification right away — from the bell icon — describing the request. Open it and you can **Accept / Decline** (check-ins) or **Confirm** (pickups) directly inline, without navigating to the full dashboard first.

THIS IS A SHORTCUT, NOT A BYPASS

The notification never contains the code itself — you still have to ask whoever is physically there for it and type it in. This just saves you a trip to the dashboard; it doesn't skip the confirmation step in any way.

Admin Guide

Staff accounts & the guardian invite code

The **Staff accounts** page is your hub for both staff and the ministry's invite code:

- **Guardian invite code** — a permanent code you share with families so they can join your ministry at signup. **Regenerate** if it's ever leaked or shared too widely — the old code stops working immediately.
- **+ Create staff or admin account** — creates a login directly (no self-signup, no email confirmation delay) and approves it immediately. Choose **Staff** or **Admin**, fill in their details, assign rooms (for staff), confirm they've consented, and hand them the email/temporary password. This is the only way to add a second admin to your ministry.

For each staff account already listed, you can toggle their **background check status**, adjust their **room assignments**, and **Approve** or **Reject** a pending application.

Rooms

Create and edit rooms (name, age range, capacity) and mark a room **active/inactive** — an inactive room stops appearing as a check-in option for guardians and as a transfer destination, without deleting its history.

Children & class assignment

The **Children** page lists every child in your ministry with their guardian's name, and a room/class selector — use it to move a child to a different default room, for example when they age up between terms. This only changes which room they're *suggested for* at their next check-in; it never touches a session already in progress. Use the search bar at the top to find a child quickly by their name or their guardian's name.

Live cross-room dashboard

See every checked-in and pending session across every room at once, grouped by room. From here you can also:

- **Transfer** a child directly into another room.
- **Override** — a manual checkout for the rare case a parent's phone is lost or dead and no code can be generated. Always requires typing a reason, which is recorded in the audit log.

Incidents

Every pickup mismatch and every staff-reported incident lands here, tagged by room and reporter. Toggle **Show resolved** to review closed incidents, and mark an open one resolved once you've followed up.

Audit log

A complete, filterable history of every safety-relevant event: check-in requested/accepted/ declined, code mismatches, checkout requested/approved, transfers, no-show flags, manual overrides, incident reports, and data purges. Filter by action type, room, date range, or search for a specific child by name.

Reports

Pick a date range to see:

- **Attendance** — counts by room and date.
- **Average pickup time** — overall and per room.
- **Incidents over time** — counts by type and date.

Data retention

Permanently deletes finished sessions (checked out, declined, or transferred — never an active session, regardless of date) older than a date you choose, along with their chat messages, chat threads, audit-log entries, and incidents.

THIS CANNOT BE UNDONE

You must type the exact cutoff date to confirm before a purge runs. Use this deliberately, as part of a retention policy — not as a routine cleanup habit.

How Shmeera Keeps Children Safe

These are the principles behind the screens in this manual — understanding them helps everyone, especially staff, know why the app sometimes asks for one more confirmation instead of moving faster.

Two-sided confirmation

A code being generated never, by itself, changes a child's status. Every check-in, checkout, decline, and transfer requires a second, independent person to actively confirm it. A guardian generating a pickup code doesn't release their child — a staff member entering that code correctly does.

A closed, guardian-controlled pickup list

A checkout can only ever be requested as the guardian themselves, or as someone that guardian specifically added to that child's pickup list. No one else — not staff, not an admin — can add themselves or anyone else to it. A person can also be explicitly **blocked**, which is different from simply not being on the list: it's a clear, visible warning rather than silence.

Codes that can't be guessed or reused

Every check-in and pickup code is generated using a cryptographically secure random process, is single-use, and expires automatically — a check-in code after several hours, a pickup code much sooner. There is no pattern to guess and no way to reuse an old one.

Visibility matches responsibility

A guardian only ever sees their own family. Staff only ever see the room(s) they're approved and assigned to. Only an admin sees everything — and only within their own ministry; a completely separate ministry using the same Shmeera deployment cannot see or affect your organization in any way, and vice versa.

A complete audit trail

Every check-in, checkout, decline, transfer, failed or mismatched code attempt, and urgent-message escalation is recorded permanently (until deliberately purged under a retention policy). If a question ever comes up about who checked a child out and when, the answer is always available to an admin.

Troubleshooting & FAQ

I didn't get my confirmation or password-reset email.

Check your spam folder first. These emails come from Shmeera's built-in mailer, which has a send-rate limit — if your ministry just onboarded several people in quick succession, a short delay is normal. If it persists, ask your admin to check with whoever manages the Shmeera project.

My child's check-in code says it expired.

Check-in codes are valid for several hours from when they're generated (long enough to cover a full service window), and pickup codes for a shorter window since they're generated right before you plan to leave. Simply generate a new one from your dashboard if it's expired.

Staff says the code doesn't match, but I'm reading it correctly.

Double check you're showing the *current* code — if you refreshed the page or generated a new one, the old one on a screenshot or a previous screen no longer works. Codes are letters/numbers only, shown in a fixed-width font to avoid ambiguity between similar-looking characters.

I was marked as a blocked pickup person by mistake.

Only the child's guardian can change a pickup person's status. Speak to them directly — they can switch you back to Active from Manage children & pickup list.

I'm staff, but I don't see the room dashboard.

You'll see a waiting screen until an admin both approves your account *and* assigns you to at least one room. If you've waited a while, contact your ministry admin.

Why did I stay signed in after I closed the app?

By design, Shmeera does not automatically sign anyone out for inactivity — sign out manually from the header menu when you're done, especially on a device other people can access.

I'm an admin — can I recover data after a purge?

No. Purging under Data Retention is permanent and cannot be undone, which is why it requires typing the exact cutoff date to confirm. Active (in-progress) sessions are never eligible for purge regardless of date, so this only ever affects history that's already finished.